

Team Digit with inputs from "The Interns"

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Besides statistics, the plethora of web stores and deal-of-the-day web sites cropping up everyday makes the question of whether online shopping is big in India redundant. Of course, it's catching on! There's no doubt that it is indeed going to be the most preferred way by which people will

individual web sites selling everything from IT goodies and flowers to books and even speciality baby products. Of course, since we weren't *too* interested in Lingerie, Art and all these other categories, we whittled down the list to about 30 of the best destinations for IT purchases. Once we had these web sites, we moved on to the enormous challenge of actually quantifying parameters such as pricing and availability of products found on these web sites. We created a mixed bag of 62 products spanning each and every category you can possibly think of. The products were selected intelligently so as to represent a near perfect cross-section of what is available in the market and what a typical Digit reader would be looking for this season. We had a couple of phones ranging from entry-level ones such as the Micromax Bling 2 to

high-end ones such as the Samsung Galaxy S II and everything in between. For cameras, we had a couple of popular entry-level DSLRs such as the Canon 1100D as well as notable Point-and-Shoots such as the hard-to-procure Panasonic Lumix TZ7. Other products we searched were some of our Best Buys from Digit's Comparison Tests. Two routers, a few portable hard drives, notebooks, several tablets, a budget Blu-ray player (Sony S380), pen drives, LCD/LED TV models and a complete mid-range rig were all included in the mixed bag of products. Apart from searching for these products and comparing their

pricing across web sites we also looked at the depth offered in each category i.e., the number of items listed, wherever available.

Scores were given for pricing in each category as well as for the availability of products. A score was obtained for each product by comparing the minimum price offered anywhere as a percentage of the price offered at that store. These scores were summed across the category. If the product was not available with a particular web site, a penalty of twice the maximum price was added as an overhead.

As the comparison progressed, 3-4 distinct categories of web sites emerged, viz., Marketplaces, Aggregators, Multi-category stockists and Speciality stockists. What also emerged were distinct core competencies or specialties that each of the multi-category web sites seemed to have fine-tuned. For instance, flipkart and adexmart have acquired quite a bit of expertise in mobile phones. Some online stores were admittedly catering to specific categories. For example, within technology as a broad space, bitfang.com, techshhop.in and many others, deal with only computer components. There were a couple of overlaps too. Naaptol.com, for instance, seemed to be a hybrid of sorts having Stock



Iconia Tab for under 30k at eBany.in

procure things in the future. As it stands today, many of us are pretty familiar with some of the well known places online. Which web store is the best for which category of products? Which one has the best range of products? Where are the best deals available? A simple Google search with "buy abc product India" may not throw up the best results as some of the sites offering the best deals may not have been properly Search Engine Optimized.

To answer these questions, we decided to undertake a massive comparison of eCommerce web sites across categories.

How we compared

Our task first began by mapping the entire online shopping universe. The exhaustive list drawn up consisted of over a hundred



A good price offered for the Galaxy Tab P1000 at IndiaPlaza



Ching's Secret

Instant, Hakka & Pad Thai Noodles,
Soups, Sauces & Miracle Masala

Ching's Khao, Baki Bhool Jao